

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN MYANMAR

Complete Community Opposition How-To

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INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Why This Matters

Across Myanmar, communities wake up to discover that the land they farm, the river they fish, the forest they have used for generations, or the hillside above their village has been handed to someone else. A dam licence. A mining concession. A special economic zone. A plantation permit. A pipeline route. A quarry.

This guide is a practical manual for those people. It explains, in concrete steps, how the approval system for large projects is supposed to work in Myanmar, where the openings are, what documentation actually moves a decision, how to organise safely, and how to use the few genuine levers that exist.

You need to hear the hardest truth first, because everything else in this guide depends on you understanding it. Myanmar is not a place where a community can rely on courts, regulators, or elected representatives to enforce the rules against a powerful developer. Since the military seized power in February 2021, already-weak institutions became weaker and more dangerous, and open protest against a project can bring arrest, imprisonment, or worse. This does not mean nothing can be done. It means the methods that work here differ from those that work in a functioning democracy, and using the wrong method can get people hurt for no gain. The whole of this guide is built around that reality.

The projects that damage communities in Myanmar are not random. They follow money and power: hydropower dams on rivers that feed millions; gold, tin, rare-earth, jade, and copper mines that poison water and swallow farmland; oil and gas pipelines that cross the country to serve export markets; plantations and agribusiness concessions carved out of forest and customary land; special economic zones that displace whole villages; sand dredging that collapses riverbanks; and infrastructure tied to foreign investment and to the military's own business networks. What they share is that those who approve them rarely bear their costs, and those who bear the costs are rarely asked.

The Strategic Framework

The core of this guide is a simple idea: **a destructive project is not a single event but a chain of decisions, and a chain can be broken at its weakest link.**

Every large project depends on a sequence: someone proposes it; a ministry or committee classifies it; an environmental or social assessment is supposed to be produced; permits and a compliance certificate are issued; land is acquired or a concession is granted; financing is arranged; and construction begins.

In a country with a tilted system, the strongest links in that chain are usually the domestic ones you cannot move: the ministry will classify the project as the developer wants, the assessment will be approved, the courts will not intervene against a connected company. But the chain does not end at the national border. Many projects in Myanmar depend on things the military government cannot fully control: international financing and its safeguard rules; foreign corporate buyers who fear reputational and legal exposure; export markets with human-rights and environmental due-diligence laws; and the simple fact of documented truth reaching the outside world.

This guide teaches you to map that chain for your specific project, identify which link is genuinely weakest given who is behind the project and who is funding it, and concentrate there.

Critical Caveat: A Tilted System Can Make Opposition Harder (But Doesn't Make It Impossible)

Throughout this guide, you will see honest assessments of what is realistic. This is deliberate. A guide that promised you could stop any project by filing the right objection would be lying, and in Myanmar that lie could get people arrested. Here is the honest frame:

When a project is private, mid-sized, and dependent on outside money or buyers, it is genuinely vulnerable.

A plantation company that needs a bank loan, a mine that sells to an international supply chain, a factory in a zone that markets itself to foreign brands — these have exposed flanks. Documented illegality, environmental harm, or land-rights violations can cost them financing, contracts, and permits in ways that domestic pressure alone never could.

When a project is driven by the state, the military, or their business partners, and serves a strategic or revenue purpose, stopping it outright is far less likely. For these, the realistic goal is usually different: delay, force mitigation, win compensation and relocation on better terms, shrink the footprint, protect the most important areas, or build the documented record that constrains the project later or supports accountability in a different forum. These are real outcomes that save homes, livelihoods, and lives — worth fighting for even when total victory is not on the table.

Knowing which situation you are in — before you act — is the single most important strategic judgment you will make. Much of this guide helps you make it accurately: acting as though a military-backed project can be stopped by a village meeting exposes people to danger for nothing, while treating a vulnerable private project as unchallengeable surrenders a real opening.

How to use this guide

Read the whole thing once before you do anything. Resist the urge to jump straight to writing letters or calling a meeting. The sequence matters: identify the target and its weak link, then document, then organise, then escalate through legal, lender, and media channels. Skipping to action before you understand your situation is the most common way communities expose themselves to risk and waste resources.

If you have very little time, read the Introduction, the section on how the system works, and the Rapid-Fire Version, then come back for the detail. If safety is your overriding concern — and in much of Myanmar it should be — read the section "When the System Is Tilted" early, because it governs how everything else should be done.

Two words of caution run through every page. First, **safety before tactics**: no document, no meeting, no protest is worth a life or a long imprisonment, and where the guide describes an action, it also describes how to weigh its risk. Second, **legality as framing**: wherever possible, frame your opposition as insisting that existing law and procedure be followed, not as political opposition to the authorities — this is both safer and, with the actors who matter (lenders, buyers, courts of the future), more persuasive.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot break a chain you cannot see.

The Bodies That Decide — And What Each One Controls

The Ministry of Natural Resources and Environmental Conservation (MONREC) and its Environmental Conservation Department (ECD). On paper, this is the central body. The ECD screens projects, decides whether a full Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA) or a lighter Initial Environmental Examination (IEE) is required, reviews the assessment, and issues the Environmental Compliance Certificate (ECC) that a project legally needs. In practice it is under-resourced, its review has been widely described as weak, and — in the words of people who have worked with it — it has

the power to bring fines and prosecutions but frequently chooses not to.

The sectoral ministries and the investment authorities. Energy and electric power, mining, agriculture, industry, and transport ministries sponsor and approve projects in their sectors. The Myanmar Investment Commission and the Directorate of Investment and Company Administration handle investment permits and company registration for larger and foreign-invested projects. These bodies often want the project to happen — the proponents' natural allies, not neutral referees.

The land administration. Under the Constitution, ultimately the State owns the land. Committees and the land-management administration handle farmland registration, and the Vacant, Fallow and Virgin (VfV) land system governs vast areas — especially in the ethnic states — that communities have used for generations without formal title. Who controls the paperwork over your land is frequently the decisive question.

Regional and state governments, and the General Administration Department (GAD). The GAD runs administration down to the village-tract level and is the spine through which orders, notices, and land actions flow. Township and district officials implement many project decisions and generate much of the documentation you need.

Ethnic administrations and armed organisations. In large parts of the country, control on the ground is contested. Ethnic armed organisations, their civil administrations, and community land-governance systems exercise real authority over territory and resources. For projects in these areas, the real decision-makers may not be those named in central law at all — a reality that is both a danger and, sometimes, an opening.

How a Decision Is Actually Made — The Journey of a Project

Knowing the sequence tells you when to act, because each stage has a window and a document.

Stage 1 — Proposal and screening. A proponent submits a project proposal. The ECD screens it and classifies it as EIA type, IEE type, or neither. This classification decides how much scrutiny and public consultation the project must undergo, and projects are sometimes classified low to avoid a full EIA. The screening decision is an early, high-value target: a project that should be EIA-type but is treated as needing no assessment is a documented procedural failure.

Stage 2 — Assessment and consultation. For an IEE or EIA, the proponent must prepare the assessment and, under the 2015 EIA Procedure, carry out public consultation — at the scoping stage and, depending on size, during report preparation. It is also the stage most often done badly — consultations announced late, held far away, in the wrong language, or skipped. Every defect here is evidence.

Stage 3 — Review and the compliance certificate. The ECD reviews the assessment and, if satisfied, issues the Environmental Compliance Certificate with conditions and an Environmental Management Plan — public-facing commitments the project must keep, and a checklist you can hold it against later.

Stage 4 — Land and permits. Farmland registration, VfV permits, concessions, and acquisition orders convert the plan into control over specific ground. This is where most families lose their land, and — crucially — where the largest share of winnable fights are found, because land actions are frequently done unlawfully or without required consent.

Stage 5 — Financing and construction. The project arranges money and begins. If financing comes from an international lender or foreign investor, that money carries safeguard rules and reputational exposure domestic approvals do not — the most important external link in the chain.

The Rulebook — The Provisions That Decide the Outcome

You do not need to be a lawyer, but you must know the handful of instruments that govern your fight:

- **The Environmental Conservation Law (No. 9 of 2012)** and the **Environmental Conservation Rules (Notification 50/2014)** — the backbone requiring environmental management and enabling the assessment system.
- **The Environmental Impact Assessment Procedure (Notification 616 of 2015)** — the detailed rulebook: screening into IEE/EIA/EMP categories, the public-consultation requirements, the Environmental Compliance Certificate, monitoring, and the appeal process. This is the single most important document for procedural challenges.
- **The 2008 Constitution**, Section 45 (the Union shall protect and conserve the natural environment) and Section 390(b) (environmental conservation as a citizen duty) — high-level hooks that legitimise environmental claims, and Section 37, under which land is ultimately owned by the State.
- **The Farmland Law (2012)** and the **Vacant, Fallow and Virgin Lands Management Law (2012, amended 2018)** — the land-tenure framework. The VfV amendment requires occupiers of land classed "vacant, fallow or virgin" to obtain a 30-year permit or face eviction and up to two years' imprisonment; most such land lies in ethnic areas and is in fact under customary use. For many communities these laws are the direct mechanism of dispossession — and

their misapplication is often your strongest documented claim.

- **The Land Acquisition, Resettlement and Rehabilitation Law (2019)** and the **Farmland Law amendment (2020)** — governing how land is taken for projects and what compensation and rehabilitation are owed.

The pattern to hold in mind: the environmental rules give you procedure and delay; the land rules are where dispossession happens and where the clearest illegality often lies; and the external rules — lender safeguards and foreign due-diligence law — are where a tilted domestic system can be bypassed.

Follow the Money — Why the System Often Leans Toward "Yes"

Understand the incentives and you understand why the gate is so often open. This is not a system with a neutral referee; its default is approval and its incentives point toward the proponent. Your leverage therefore rarely comes from persuading the domestic decision-maker on the merits — it comes from raising the cost, legal, financial, and reputational, to the actors who can still be moved.

The Overseers — Who Watches the Decision-Makers

In a functioning system, the overseers are courts, an ombudsman, an auditor, a free press, and elected representatives. In Myanmar most are compromised, absent, or dangerous to invoke against power: courts do not reliably act against connected projects, media inside the country works under severe repression, and complaint channels exist on paper but rarely bite.

But some overseers do function, and they sit outside the government's control:

- **International financial institutions' accountability mechanisms** — the independent complaint bodies attached to development banks, which can investigate whether a financed project broke the bank's own environmental and social rules.
- **International brands' and buyers' due-diligence and grievance systems** — the compliance processes of foreign companies that purchase Myanmar commodities and fear legal and reputational exposure under supply-chain laws in their home markets.
- **International documentation and accountability bodies** — the UN mechanisms and independent investigators building records of abuses, and the human-rights organisations whose reports move governments and investors.
- **Exile and civil-society structures** — parallel and community bodies, land-rights networks, and diaspora organisations that can carry documentation to forums the domestic system has closed.

These are the overseers your strategy should be built to reach. The rest of this guide is, in large part, about how to produce documentation strong enough to move them.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

The numbers below are not statistics from a database; no reliable dataset of Myanmar campaign outcomes exists, and anyone who gives you one is guessing. They are realistic planning estimates drawn from documented cases and the experience of communities and organisations that have fought these projects. Their purpose is not prediction but prioritisation: they tell you where to put your limited strength. Treat them as a guide to which levers are worth pulling, not as a promise.

Individual Step Success Rates

The percentages describe how often a well-executed action *materially affects the outcome* — meaning it contributes to stopping, shrinking, delaying, or improving compensation for a project — not how often it produces total victory on its own.

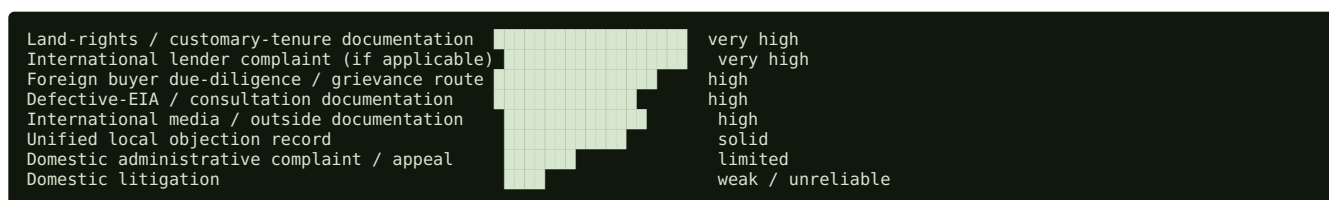
Action	Materially affects outcome	Notes
Documenting a land-rights or customary-tenure violation	45-65%	The strongest domestic lever; dispossession is often unlawful
Complaint to an international lender's accountability mechanism	40-60%	Only where a covered lender is involved; can force review and delay
Reaching a foreign buyer's due-diligence/grievance process	35-55%	Where the commodity enters an international supply chain
Documenting a defective or skipped EIA/IEE	30-50%	Procedural gate; strongest as delay and as evidence for

consultation		others
Independent international media / documentation reaching outside	30-50%	Raises cost to financiers and buyers; slow but durable
Building a documented, unified local objection record	30-45%	Foundational; multiplies the force of every other lever
Domestic administrative complaint / appeal under the EIA Procedure	15-30%	Rarely decisive alone; useful to build the record and force response
Domestic litigation against a connected project	5-20%	Unreliable; occasionally useful for delay or record
Open street protest against the project	Not scored	High personal risk under current conditions; see safety guidance

Read this table as a map. The high-value levers are land-rights documentation and the external channels — lenders, buyers, international documentation. The domestic legal and administrative channels are worth using mainly to build the record and force responses that feed those external levers, not as standalone routes to victory.

Effectiveness Visualization

The bars show relative leverage — how much a well-run version of each action tends to move a Myanmar outcome. Longer is stronger.



The shape of this chart is the whole strategy in one picture. Strength lives at the top — in documenting dispossession and in the channels that reach outside the domestic system. Weakness lives at the bottom, in the domestic legal machinery that a tilted system controls. Build your campaign to spend most of its energy at the top.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

When these actions are combined into a single campaign, their importance is not equal. Ranked by how much each contributes to a realistic result:

1. **Accurate target and leverage identification.** Choosing the right weak link — usually land rights or an external financier/buyer — determines everything.
2. **Land-rights and tenure documentation.**
3. **The external channel** — lender complaint, buyer grievance, or international documentation — matched to who actually funds and buys from the project.
4. **A unified, well-built local objection record.**
5. **Procedural (EIA/consultation) documentation.** Valuable as delay and as evidence, weaker as a standalone.
6. **Media strategy**, sequenced carefully and safely, to amplify the record to the actors who can move.
7. **Domestic legal and administrative filings**, used chiefly to build the record and force responses, not relied on to win.

What Myanmar Campaigns Actually Show

Several hard lessons recur across documented Myanmar experiences, and they should shape your expectations.

The biggest, most famous fights show both the ceiling and the possibility. The country's most prominent dam controversy saw a massive, internationally financed hydropower project suspended after sustained domestic and international attention — proof that even flagship projects are not always unstoppable, but also a reminder that suspension is not the same as cancellation, and that outcomes can shift again with the political weather.

Land is where most communities actually lose — and where the clearest wrongs are recorded. The VFV land system and unlawful acquisition have dispossessed enormous numbers of people, disproportionately in ethnic areas. But precisely because so much of this is done without the consent or process the law nominally requires, the land-rights violation is frequently the best-documented, most defensible claim a community has, and the one most likely to move an outside financier or buyer.

The external levers work when they exist and fail when they don't. Complaints to lender accountability mechanisms and pressure through foreign buyers have forced reviews, delays, and improvements — but only for projects actually connected to such money. For a purely domestic, military-linked project with no international financing or export market, these levers may simply not be available, and pretending otherwise wastes effort.

Safety shapes everything now. Since the 2021 coup, the space for open opposition has narrowed drastically and the personal risk has risen. Campaigns that succeed today are careful, documentation-led, and oriented toward external forums rather than domestic confrontation.

Delay and mitigation are real victories. A footprint shrunk, a sacred or vital area protected, a compensation package improved, a relocation made lawful and humane — these save real homes and livelihoods. Judge your campaign by these outcomes, not only by the rare total stoppage.

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Before you write a single letter or call a single meeting, you must answer a set of questions about the project you face. The answers determine which link in the chain is weakest, which lever is actually open to you, and — critically in Myanmar — how much personal risk any given action carries.

Core Questions You Must Answer

Question 1: Who is really behind this project, and how exposed are they?

Everything flows from this. Find out who the proponent actually is — not just the name on the notice, but the beneficial owner, the parent company, and any military or connected interest behind it. A private company dependent on outside money is exposed. A joint venture with a military-linked holding company, or a project serving a State revenue or strategic purpose, is far less so.

Ask: Is this a domestic private firm, a foreign investor, a joint venture, a State enterprise, or a military-linked business? Does it need a bank loan or international financing to proceed? Does it sell into an international supply chain? Who are its partners and buyers? The more the project depends on money and markets outside the government's control, the more leverage you have.

Question 2: What stage is the project at, and which window is still open?

A project you can still affect is one where a required step has not yet been completed. Has it been screened and classified yet? Has an EIA or IEE been produced, and has the public-consultation stage happened or is it coming? Has the Environmental Compliance Certificate been issued? Has land been formally acquired, or are the acquisition notices still to come? Has financing closed?

Each unfinished step is a window. The earlier you engage, the more windows remain and the more options you have. A project still at screening or consultation is far more vulnerable than one already built. If land has not yet been formally taken, protecting tenure is still possible; if the compliance certificate is not yet issued, the procedural gate is still live.

Question 3: What is the land situation, and whose consent was required?

This is often the decisive question in Myanmar. Whose land is it, in fact and in law? Is it registered farmland, or land classed as vacant, fallow or virgin, or customary land held without formal title? Has anyone applied for or been granted VFV permits over it? Were the people actually using the land consulted or compensated, and was any acquisition carried out with the notices, process, and compensation the law requires?

Because so much dispossession in Myanmar is done unlawfully or without required process — especially on customary and ethnic land — the land question is frequently where the clearest, most defensible violation lies.

Question 4: What external channels does this project touch?

List every connection the project has to the world outside the domestic system. Is there an international lender — a development bank, a multilateral, an export credit agency — anywhere in the financing? Is there a foreign corporate investor with a reputation to protect? Does the commodity (a mineral, gas, timber, an agricultural product, a manufactured good) enter an international supply chain subject to due-diligence laws? Is any international body already documenting the area or the company?

Each such connection is a potential external lever — a forum outside the government's control where documented harm can raise the project's cost.

Question 5: What is the safety environment, and what can be done without unacceptable risk?

This question governs all the others in present-day Myanmar. Who controls the territory where the project sits — the military, an ethnic armed organisation, a contested mix? What has happened to people who have objected to projects or to authority in this area recently? What forms of activity are being punished, and how severely? Which actions can be taken quietly (documentation, private complaints, reaching outside contacts) and which cannot be taken safely at all (open protest, public confrontation)?

You must answer this honestly and let it shape every choice.

Worked example: which lever is actually open

Consider a village facing a proposed agribusiness plantation on land the community has farmed for generations but which the authorities have classed as "vacant, fallow and virgin." A survey team has appeared; no compensation has been discussed; families fear eviction.

Working the five questions: **Who is behind it?** A domestic company seeking to sell its produce to regional and international buyers, and needing a bank facility to develop the concession — exposed on two fronts. **What stage?** The concession is being processed but land has not been formally cleared and no compliance certificate is yet issued — several windows still open. **Land situation?** The land is under active customary cultivation but unregistered; classing it as VFV to grant it to the company, without the consent the law nominally requires, is the core wrong — and the strongest documented claim. **External channels?** The bank financing and the international buyers are the two levers outside the government's reach. **Safety?** Open protest is dangerous; quiet documentation and outside contact are feasible.

The analysis points clearly: this is not a fight to be waged by public confrontation, but by documenting the customary tenure and the unlawful VFV classification and carrying that record to the company's financier and buyers through their grievance and due-diligence channels — while using any procedural defect to add delay. The weak link is the money and the markets, reached through the land-rights violation. That is where the village's limited strength should go.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION

Documentation is the single most important thing a Myanmar community can produce, because it is the raw material every effective lever depends on. A lender's accountability mechanism, a foreign buyer's compliance office, an international investigator, a future court — none of them can act on your word alone. They act on evidence: dated, specific, verifiable records of what exists now, what the project is, and what harm is being done.

Documentation is also, in present conditions, comparatively safe. Gathering evidence quietly exposes people far less than public protest, and it builds the foundation for every other action.

The Three Documentation Layers

Effective documentation works in three layers: the baseline conditions before the project, the project and the process itself, and the human and institutional impacts. Each answers a different question and serves a different lever. Build all three.

LAYER 1: BASELINE CONDITIONS DOCUMENTATION

This layer records what exists now, before the project changes or destroys it.

Document the land and its use: who farms which plots, for how long, under what customary or registered arrangement; the boundaries as the community understands them; the crops, grazing, forest use, water sources, and fishing that people depend on. Photograph and map it, with dates. Record the state of the environment: the river's flow and clarity, the fish and wildlife, the forest cover, the soil, the wells and streams people drink from. Record the community itself: how many households, how many people, the sacred and cultural sites, the graves, the schools and clinics, the things that make this a place and not just a plot.

Wherever possible, tie your baseline to something external and dated — a photograph with a visible date, a satellite

image, an older map or record, a receipt or registration document, a written account signed and dated by elders. The goal is that a stranger reviewing your file years later can see clearly what was there before and cannot dismiss it as recollection.

LAYER 2: PROJECT AND PROCESS ANALYSIS

This layer records the project itself and how it was approved — the procedural spine of your case. Obtain and preserve every document the project generates: the project proposal, any screening decision, the EIA or IEE if one exists, the Environmental Compliance Certificate and its conditions, concession or permit documents, land classification and acquisition notices, and any public announcements.

Then compare what happened against what the rules require. Was the project screened and classified correctly, or was it treated as needing no assessment when its scale suggests it should be EIA-type? Was the required public consultation held — and if so, was it announced in time, held accessibly, conducted in a language people understood, and genuinely open to objection, or was it a formality? Does the EIA actually assess the impacts, or does it read, as observers have said of many Myanmar EIAs, more like a promotional document for the project than an honest assessment? Were the compliance certificate's conditions met? Was the land classified and acquired with the notices, consent, and compensation the law requires?

Every gap between what the rules require and what actually happened is a documented procedural failure. Record each one specifically: the rule, the requirement, what happened instead, and the evidence. This is what turns a grievance into a case.

LAYER 3: HUMAN AND INSTITUTIONAL IMPACT DOCUMENTATION

This layer records what the project does to people and how the institutions responded. Document the impacts on livelihoods: land lost, crops and income foregone, wells and fisheries destroyed, families displaced, the cost of relocation borne by those least able to pay. Document the health and environmental harms with as much specificity as you can: what was contaminated, who fell ill, what the water looks like now. Document the human cost of the process: intimidation, threats, arrests, or coercion used to secure consent or silence objection — recorded carefully and, where naming individuals could endanger them, with appropriate protection of identities.

Also document the institutional response — or its absence. When the community raised concerns, what did officials do? Were complaints acknowledged, investigated, ignored, or met with pressure? This record of institutional failure is exactly what an external overseer — a lender's mechanism, a buyer's compliance office, an international body — needs in order to conclude that the domestic system did not, and will not, provide a remedy, which is often the precondition for them to act.

How to Structure Your Documentation

Keep your evidence organised so it can be handed to someone else and understood without you. Maintain a simple, dated log of events — what happened, when, who was involved, what evidence exists. Keep documents, photographs, and maps labelled with dates and locations. Keep at least one secure copy somewhere the project's backers cannot reach it, and ideally a copy held safely outside the immediate area. In present conditions, think carefully about where and how digital records are stored and who can access them; security of your documentation is part of the safety of your people.

Structure the file around the three layers and around the specific violations you have found, so that when the moment comes to send it to a lender, a buyer, a journalist, or a lawyer, you are assembling from an organised archive rather than scrambling.

Common Documentation Pitfalls (What Fails)

Weak documentation is vague, undated, and general — "the company destroyed our land" without showing which land, when, held how, and with what proof. It fails to connect a specific harm to a specific requirement of the law. And it is stored insecurely, so it can be lost, seized, or used to identify people.

Strong documentation is the opposite: specific, dated, tied to external reference points, organised around clear violations, cautious about identities, and securely kept. It reads calmly and lets the facts carry the weight.

Documentation Budget Breakdown

Documentation is deliberately low-cost, which is part of why it is the right first priority for communities with little money. The main costs are a means of taking dated photographs; simple materials for mapping and record-keeping; secure

storage, including a safe off-site copy; and, where possible, modest support for someone trusted to maintain the archive carefully over time. Occasionally there is a cost to obtaining copies of official documents or to secure communication with outside contacts.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This section is a practical checklist of the specific records that strengthen a Myanmar case, and where they can usually be obtained.

The project's environmental documents. The screening decision, the EIA or IEE, the Environmental Compliance Certificate and its conditions, and the Environmental Management Plan. Where the system is functioning, these are meant to be obtainable through the Environmental Conservation Department and may be referenced in project announcements; assessments are sometimes disclosed during consultation. If you can obtain the assessment, it is a goldmine: its own admissions of impact, and the gaps between its promises and reality, become your evidence. Where the documents cannot be obtained, the *absence* of a required assessment or certificate is itself documentable and important.

The land records. Farmland registration documents, VFV land classification and permit records, concession and lease documents, and any acquisition notices. These flow through the land administration and the General Administration Department at township and district level. They establish who holds what on paper — which you then compare against who actually uses the land in fact. The mismatch is frequently the heart of your case. Where formal records do not exist because tenure is customary, your own carefully built record of long-standing use, attested by elders and neighbours, becomes the primary evidence of the right that is being violated.

The proponent's identity and backing. Company registration and investment-permit records, obtainable in principle through the company and investment administration, establish who owns and funds the project. Where official searches are difficult, international corporate databases, investigative reporting, and civil-society research can often fill the gap.

The financing trail. Any indication of who funds the project — a development bank, a commercial lender, an export credit agency, a foreign investor. Loan announcements, corporate filings, project websites, and the reporting of researchers and journalists are the usual sources. This is among the most valuable information you can find, because a covered international financier opens the accountability-mechanism lever.

The buyer and supply-chain trail. Where the project produces a commodity, evidence of where it is sold — the buyers, the traders, the international brands at the end of the chain. Trade data, company sustainability disclosures, and the work of supply-chain researchers are the sources. This opens the foreign due-diligence lever.

The consultation and objection record. Notices of consultation, attendance records, minutes, and — crucially — your own contemporaneous account of what the consultation actually was: when it was announced, who could attend, what language it was in, whether objection was genuinely possible. Where consultation was skipped or was a formality, your record of that fact is the evidence of the procedural failure.

The baseline evidence. Dated photographs, maps, satellite imagery, older records, and signed accounts establishing what existed before — as described in the documentation section. Much of this you create yourself; some can be supplemented from public satellite imagery and historical maps.

The impact evidence. Records of harm as it occurs — photographs of clearing, contamination, or displacement; accounts of livelihood loss; health information; and records of any intimidation or coercion, handled with care for people's safety.

A note on access, and on safety. In a functioning system many of these records are obtainable through official channels and information requests. In present-day Myanmar, official channels are unreliable and some inquiries can draw dangerous attention. Weigh every act of gathering against its risk. Favour records you can obtain quietly, information already public, and the evidence you create yourself. Lean on trusted civil-society organisations, land-rights networks, and researchers — inside and outside the country — who may already hold relevant information and who can gather or receive material more safely than an exposed villager can.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION

Critical Insight About Organizing

In a functioning democracy, organising means building a large, visible movement that pressures elected officials through public demonstration. In Myanmar today, that model can get people imprisoned or killed, and it often does not even reach

the actors who can actually move the project. So the organising this guide describes is different. Its purpose is not public spectacle; it is to build a **unified, disciplined, well-documented community** that can hold together under pressure, produce a credible record, and channel that record to external levers — while keeping its people as safe as possible.

The strength you are building is not the size of a crowd. It is unity, discipline, careful documentation, trusted outside connections, and the ability to act quietly and in concert.

PHASE 1: FOUNDATION (Weeks 1-4)

Begin quietly and close to home. The first task is to establish, among the people directly affected, a shared and accurate understanding of what the project is, what stage it is at, and what is really at stake.

Identify the small group of trusted people who will carry the work: those respected in the community, careful in temperament, and able to keep confidences. Keep this core group tight at first. Establish, from the very beginning, the security practices that will govern everything: how information is shared, what is written down and where, what is kept off phones and out of public view, and how people protect one another. In present conditions, these practices are not optional; they are the difference between an effective campaign and a dangerous exposure.

Begin the documentation described earlier — the baseline, the project records, the tenure evidence — as the community's first concrete shared task.

PHASE 2: PUBLIC LAUNCH (Weeks 4-12)

"Public launch" must be understood carefully in the Myanmar context. It does not mean a demonstration. It means widening the circle of the affected community into a coherent, agreed position — reaching the households that will be affected, aligning them around a shared and accurate account, and building consensus about goals and limits. What does the community actually want — the project stopped, the footprint shrunk, the sacred land protected, fair compensation and lawful relocation? What risks is the community willing and unwilling to take?

This is also the stage to make first, careful contact with the outside allies who will matter: trusted civil-society organisations, land-rights networks, legal-aid providers, and researchers who work on these issues. These contacts should be approached with discretion, through trusted intermediaries where possible.

PHASE 3: COALITION EXPANSION (Months 3-8)

Now widen the circle beyond the immediately affected community to those who share the stake or the risk: neighbouring villages facing the same project or the same company, communities affected by the same river or the same concession, and the broader networks — land-rights, environmental, ethnic community, and humanitarian — that connect local struggles to national and international attention.

Coalition in Myanmar is often built horizontally and quietly, through trusted relationships rather than public alliances. Its value is real: it multiplies documentation, spreads risk, connects you to the organisations that can carry your case to lenders, buyers, and international bodies, and ensures that if one node is silenced, the record and the effort survive elsewhere.

PHASE 4: SUSTAINED PRESSURE (Months 6-18)

Most consequential projects are not stopped quickly. The final phase is about endurance: keeping the community united, the documentation current, and the external channels engaged over the long run, while managing risk and morale.

Sustained pressure in this context means continuously feeding the external levers — updating the lender complaint, the buyer's compliance office, the international documentation — with fresh, dated evidence as the project develops; maintaining the unity and security of the community; and being ready to act when a window opens, such as a financing decision, a buyer's review, or a shift in the political situation.

Worked example: a community that unlocks the strong levers

Return to the village facing the agribusiness plantation on its customary land. Consider how organising, done in the Myanmar way, unlocks the levers that matter.

In the foundation phase, a small trusted core establishes the facts and, the security practices, and begins documenting who has farmed which plots for how long — the tenure record that is the community's strongest asset. In the widening phase, the affected households align around a clear, shared goal: not vague resistance, but a specific demand that their

customary tenure be respected and the unlawful VFV classification reversed, with lawful compensation if any land is taken. They make careful contact with a land-rights network and a legal-aid group.

In the coalition phase, they connect quietly with neighbouring villages facing the same company and with researchers tracking the company's financing and buyers. Now the village has become **a community that unlocks the strong levers**: its documented, unified tenure claim, carried by trusted allies, reaches the company's bank and international buyers through their grievance and due-diligence channels — the actors who can actually impose a cost. In the sustained phase, the community keeps that pressure alive until the company, facing financing and reputational risk it did not expect, delays, reduces its claim, or comes to terms. The village never held a demonstration. It organised, documented, and reached outside — and that is what moved the outcome.

Opposition Building Budget: Year-Long Campaign

A careful Myanmar campaign is not expensive in money, though it is costly in effort and risk. The main resources needed over a year are: the low-cost documentation materials already described; secure communication and storage; modest support for the trusted people who carry the sustained work; the costs of discreet travel and contact with outside allies; and, where a legal or lender complaint is pursued, the support of a legal-aid provider or an ally organisation, which is often provided without charge to communities.

STEP 4: LEGAL CHALLENGES

Legal challenge in Myanmar must be understood realistically. The domestic courts do not reliably act against connected projects, and litigation against a powerful developer rarely wins outright, especially under current conditions. Yet "legal" work still matters — not mainly as a route to a winning judgment, but as a way to establish rights on the record, force procedural responses, create delay, and build the documented case that external levers rely on. Think of the legal dimension in three tracks, and put most of your weight on the two that actually carry force here.

TRACK 1: THE ASSESSMENT (a real but weak gate)

The environmental assessment regime — the EIA Procedure, the compliance certificate, the consultation requirements — is a genuine set of legal obligations. A project that skipped a required assessment, was misclassified to avoid one, conducted a sham consultation, or breached its compliance-certificate conditions is in procedural violation.

The realistic value of this track is limited but real. Domestically, an administrative complaint or appeal under the EIA Procedure rarely stops a connected project, but it forces the authorities to respond, documents the violation on the record, and can create delay. More importantly, a documented procedural failure is powerful *outside* the domestic system: it is exactly the kind of finding that a lender's accountability mechanism or a foreign buyer's compliance office treats as serious, because it shows the project did not meet the standards those actors require. So pursue the assessment track chiefly to build the record and feed the external levers — not in the expectation that a domestic regulator will halt the project on procedural grounds.

TRACK 2: THE LAND RIGHTS (where most is won)

For most Myanmar communities, the land-rights track is where the strongest claim lives, because dispossession is so often carried out unlawfully. The relevant instruments are the Farmland Law, the Vacant, Fallow and Virgin Lands Management Law and its 2018 amendment, the Land Acquisition, Resettlement and Rehabilitation Law, and the constitutional and customary dimensions of tenure.

The claims that carry weight are concrete: that land classed as "vacant, fallow or virgin" was in fact under active customary cultivation, and its classification and transfer therefore violated the rights of the people using it; that acquisition proceeded without the notices, consent, or compensation the law requires; that resettlement and rehabilitation obligations were ignored; that the process breached protections owed to the occupiers. These are not abstract arguments — they are specific, documentable violations tied to specific families and plots.

Even where a domestic court will not enforce these claims, establishing them clearly on the record does real work. It is the foundation of any complaint to a lender or buyer, whose own standards require respect for land and tenure rights and free, prior and informed consent. It supports the case that the domestic system offered no remedy. This is the track on which most is actually won in Myanmar — not always in a courtroom, but through the leverage a well-documented tenure violation creates.

TRACK 3: THE LENDERS AND THE COURTS OF ELSEWHERE

The third track reaches outside the domestic system entirely, and for many projects it is the strongest of all.

Where an international financial institution funds the project, its **independent accountability mechanism** can receive a complaint from affected communities alleging that the project breached the institution's environmental and social safeguards — including on assessment, consultation, land, and resettlement. Such a complaint can trigger an independent investigation, dialogue, and pressure domestic channels cannot, and can force delay, mitigation, or improved terms. Where a covered lender exists, a strong, well-documented complaint should be central to the strategy.

Where the project's commodity enters an international supply chain, the **due-diligence and grievance processes of foreign buyers and investors** — increasingly backed by supply-chain and human-rights laws in their home countries — provide another external forum. A documented violation delivered to a buyer's compliance office can put a valuable contract at risk, which is a language the proponent understands even when domestic law is not.

And international documentation and accountability bodies — UN mechanisms, human-rights organisations, and, in some cases, courts and investigators in other jurisdictions — can receive and act on records of serious abuses, especially where the harm rises to the level of grave violations. These are longer and more specialised routes, pursued with expert help, but they are real, and they are wholly outside the domestic system's control.

The three legal challenge types

In summary, your "legal" toolkit has three types of challenge, ranked by their realistic force in Myanmar: **the land-rights claim**, strongest because dispossession is so often unlawful and because it feeds every external lever; **the external complaint** — to a lender's mechanism, a buyer's compliance process, or an international body — strongest where the relevant connection exists; and **the procedural (assessment) challenge**, useful mainly to build the record, force responses, and create delay. Domestic litigation sits underneath all three: occasionally worth pursuing for delay or record, but never to be relied upon.

Legal Strategy Decision Tree

Choose your track by answering, in order: **Is land being taken from people using it, without proper process?** If yes, the land-rights track is your spine — document tenure and the violation, and build from there. **Is there an international lender or foreign buyer connected to the project?** If yes, the external complaint is your most powerful lever — prepare it carefully with expert help. **Is there a procedural defect in the assessment or consultation?** If yes, use it to force responses, create delay, and strengthen the external complaints. **Is a domestic filing safe and potentially useful for delay or record?** If yes, consider it — but never rely on it, and always weigh its risk.

Litigation and Advocacy Success Factors

What distinguishes effective legal-track work in Myanmar is not legal brilliance but preparation and matching. The community that succeeds has documented its tenure and the violation meticulously; has identified the right external forum for its specific project; has enlisted expert help — a legal-aid provider, a land-rights organisation, a specialist in lender complaints — early; frames its claims around law and rights rather than politics; and manages the risk of every filing. The community that fails relies on a domestic court to do what domestic courts here do not do, acts without documentation, misjudges its leverage, or exposes its people to danger for a filing that was never going to bite.

What to Avoid

Do not pin your hopes on a domestic court judgment against a connected project; it rarely comes. Do not file anything that requires exposing people to danger without a clear, proportionate purpose. Do not let the legal track become a substitute for documentation and external engagement — it is their servant, not their replacement. And do not proceed on the most sensitive claims — especially those touching grave abuses or powerful actors — without expert guidance on both strategy and safety.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

Evidence does not speak for itself. The same documented facts must be translated into different arguments for different audiences, because a lender's accountability officer, a foreign buyer's compliance team, an international investigator, and a journalist each respond to different things. Learning to reframe one body of evidence for each audience is what

multiplies its force.

For an international lender, frame the evidence as a breach of the lender's own safeguard standards. Lenders commit to environmental and social requirements — on assessment, consultation, land acquisition, resettlement, and free, prior and informed consent. Your argument is not "this project is unjust"; it is "this project, which your institution finances, violated these specific standards, in these documented ways, and the affected communities have had no remedy."

For a foreign buyer or investor, frame the evidence as legal and reputational risk in their supply chain. Their concern is exposure under due-diligence laws and the reputational cost of being linked to dispossession or environmental harm. Your argument is: "the commodity you buy is produced on land taken unlawfully from these communities, with these documented harms; here is the evidence; here is the risk you carry."

For an international body or investigator, frame the evidence as a pattern of violations against a legal or human-rights standard, documented rigorously.

For a journalist, frame the evidence as a story with human stakes, a clear wrong, and a powerful actor who can be held responsible — which the next section addresses in detail.

The discipline in every case is the same: lead with the specific, dated, verifiable fact; connect it to the standard or interest that moves this particular audience; and let the calm accumulation of documented truth, not the intensity of feeling, carry the argument. In a tilted system, your credibility is your scarcest asset. Overstatement, unverified claims, or anger that outruns the evidence hand the other side an easy dismissal. Precise, sourced, understated evidence is far harder to ignore.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY

Media in the Myanmar context is a double-edged tool, and it must be handled with unusual care. Done well, independent and international media raises the cost of a project to its financiers and buyers and carries documented truth to the outside forums that can act. Done carelessly, it can expose people to grave danger. This section is about using media's real power while protecting the people who provide it.

How Journalists Actually Work

Understand the landscape first. Inside Myanmar, independent journalism operates under severe repression; reporters and sources face real danger, and much domestic media is unfree. The media that matters most for your strategy is therefore often **exile, diaspora, and international** — outlets and reporters working from outside the country or covering it from abroad, and specialist environmental and human-rights journalists who follow these issues. These journalists work as journalists everywhere do: they need verifiable facts, a clear story, human voices, and evidence they can stand behind. But they also understand — and share responsibility for — the danger to sources, and the good ones will work with you to protect identities.

The Newsworthiness Formula

A project becomes a story when it combines a clear wrong, a human stake, a powerful and nameable actor, and solid evidence. In the Myanmar context, stories that travel are those that connect a local harm to something the outside world is watching: a link to international finance or a global brand; a documented pattern of dispossession, especially on ethnic and customary land; grave abuses; or a connection to actors already under scrutiny. Your documented evidence — the tenure violation, the financing trail, the buyer link, the procedural failure — is what turns your community's plight into a story that a serious outlet will carry.

Know the Outlets That Cover This Beat

Identify, with the help of your civil-society allies, the specific journalists and outlets that credibly cover Myanmar land, environment, and human rights — the exile and diaspora outlets, the international wire services and papers with a Myanmar or regional focus, the specialist environmental and human-rights publications, and the researchers whose work feeds them.

Building Reporter Relationships (The Key)

The heart of media work is a trusted relationship with a small number of credible journalists, built through intermediaries and handled securely. Provide them with verified, well-organised evidence; be honest about what you know and do not know; and be scrupulously careful about the safety of sources.

Why media matters even when it doesn't make the front page

Even coverage that does not stop a project does essential work. It puts documented facts into the international record, where lenders, buyers, and investigators can find them. It signals to financiers and brands that their association with the project carries reputational cost. It supports the case that the domestic system offered no remedy.

Sample Media Timeline

Media should follow, not lead, your documentation and safety work. Early on, while you build the record, media work is limited to quietly identifying the right journalists and allies. Only once you have solid, verified evidence and have thought through the risks do you make careful contact. As the campaign matures and external complaints are filed, coordinated media can amplify those complaints to the actors who can move. Throughout, the pace is set by two things: the strength of your evidence and the safety of your people. Never let a media opportunity outrun either.

Media Measurement

Measure media not by volume but by effect: Did it reach the financiers, buyers, or bodies you are trying to move? Did it enter the record your external complaints rely on? Did it raise the project's reputational cost? Did it protect, rather than endanger, your people?

EMAILS & LETTERS

The following templates are starting points, not scripts. Adapt every one to your specific facts, and — this cannot be overstated — weigh the safety of every communication before you send it. In present conditions, consider carefully what is put in writing, how it is sent, who is named, and how the sender and sources are protected. Where a communication could endanger people, route it through a trusted ally or organisation, protect identities, and take security advice first. Several of these letters are best sent not by exposed villagers at all, but by allied organisations on the community's behalf.

8A. Email to a journalist (story pitch)

Subject: Documented land-rights and environmental concerns — [project], [region]

Dear [Name],

I am writing on behalf of [community/organisation] regarding [project], a [type] project affecting [area]. We have assembled dated documentation of [customary land use being classified and taken without lawful process / a defective or absent environmental assessment / specific environmental and livelihood harms], and of the project's links to [financier/buyer].

We believe this raises issues of clear public interest: [one line on the wrong and the powerful actor responsible]. We can provide organised evidence and, with appropriate protection of identities and safety, connect you with people directly affected.

The safety of those involved is our first concern, and we would want to discuss how to protect sources before proceeding. Could we find a secure way to speak?

[Contact, via a secure channel]

8B. Objection during the environmental assessment / consultation

To: [Environmental Conservation Department / relevant authority] Re: Objection concerning [project] — [reference]

We, the undersigned affected community of [area], submit this objection regarding [project].

1. **Classification and assessment:** [State the concern — e.g., the project appears to warrant a full EIA but has been treated otherwise; or the assessment omits identified impacts.]
2. **Consultation:** [State the defect — e.g., consultation was not announced with adequate notice / not accessible / not conducted in a language the community understands / did not permit genuine objection.]
3. **Impacts:** [Summarise the documented impacts on land, water, livelihoods, and the community.]

We request that these concerns be recorded, that the required procedures be fully complied with, and that no compliance certificate issue until they are addressed. We reserve all rights.

[Community / organisation]

8C. Assertion of customary tenure / objection to VFV classification

To: [Relevant land authority / General Administration Department] Re: Land at [location] — assertion of existing use and objection to classification/transfer

The land at [location] has been under continuous customary cultivation and use by the families of [community] for [period]. It is not, in fact, vacant, fallow or virgin, and its classification and/or transfer as such does not reflect the true situation on the ground.

We attach documentation of long-standing use [list]. We object to any classification, permit, or acquisition that disregards this existing use, and we assert the rights of the families concerned. We request that no action be taken over this land inconsistent with these rights, and that this objection be placed on the record.

[Community / organisation]

8D. Letter challenging a concession or a missing assessment

To: [Relevant authority / proponent] Re: [Project/concession] — request for lawful process

We understand that [project/concession] is proceeding [without a required environmental assessment / on the basis of a classification that appears inconsistent with its scale / over land under existing customary use]. We request confirmation of [the assessment status / the legal basis for the land classification / the compensation and resettlement provisions], and that the project not proceed until the requirements of [the EIA Procedure / the applicable land laws] are met.

[Community / organisation]

8E. Complaint to an international lender's accountability mechanism

To: [Accountability Mechanism of the financing institution] Re: Complaint concerning [project] financed by [institution]

We, communities affected by [project], submit this complaint. We believe the project has breached [the institution's] environmental and social requirements, including on [environmental assessment / meaningful consultation / land acquisition and involuntary resettlement / free, prior and informed consent], in the following documented ways: [list, each tied to the relevant standard and to dated evidence].

We have sought remedy through [domestic channels] without result [detail]. We request that the mechanism assess this complaint, and we can provide organised documentation. We ask that appropriate measures be taken to protect complainants from reprisal.

[Community / organisation, via trusted ally]

8F. Letter to halt an eviction pending lawful process

To: [Relevant authority] Re: [Location] — request to halt action pending lawful process

We are informed that steps are being taken to remove the families of [community] from land at [location]. We assert that this land is under existing lawful use, that the requirements of [applicable law] for acquisition, compensation, and resettlement have not been met, and that any removal absent lawful process would be unlawful.

We request that no removal proceed until the required process, consent, and compensation are demonstrably fulfilled, and that this letter be placed on the record.

[Community / organisation]

8G. Press release (for use by an allied organisation)

For release: Communities in [area] document land-rights and environmental concerns over [project]

[Area] — Communities affected by [project] have documented [the core wrong], including [one or two specific, verified facts]. The project is linked to [financier/buyer]. Affected people are calling for [the specific demand — lawful process, respect for tenure, halt pending compliance].

"[Short, human quote — used only with consent and with identity protected as needed.]"

Documentation is available to accredited journalists and relevant bodies through [allied organisation], with appropriate protection of sources.

8H. Letter to a land-rights or legal-aid organisation

Dear [Organisation],

We are a community in [area] facing [project], which threatens [our land / environment / homes] through [summary]. We have begun documenting [tenure, impacts, process] and seek your guidance and support on [land-rights strategy / a lender or buyer complaint / safety].

We would welcome a secure conversation about how to proceed. The safety of those involved is our first concern.

[Community contact, via secure channel]

Important Caveat

Every template above must yield to safety. In present-day Myanmar, a letter that would be routine elsewhere can carry real risk. Before sending anything: consider whether it should be sent by the community or by an ally on its behalf; protect the identities of those who could be endangered; use secure channels; take advice from trusted organisations; and never let the act of filing expose people to a danger out of proportion to what the filing can achieve. The letters are tools for building a record and reaching those who can act — not ends in themselves, and never worth a person's safety.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

If you can do only a few things, do these, in this order, and do them safely.

First, establish who is behind the project and how it is funded and sold. This single answer tells you whether you have real leverage (a private, financed, export-linked project) or must aim for delay and better terms (a State or military-linked one). Spend your first effort here.

Second, document the land and its use — quietly and thoroughly. Who has farmed, grazed, or used which land, for how long, and how. Dated photographs, a simple map, signed accounts from elders. In Myanmar, the tenure record is usually your strongest asset, and it cannot be recreated once the land is taken.

Third, document the process failures. Was there an environmental assessment and a real consultation, or not? Was the land classified and taken lawfully, or not? Each gap between the rule and the reality is evidence.

Fourth, reach the external lever that fits your project. If an international lender funds it, prepare a complaint to that lender's accountability mechanism. If a foreign buyer purchases its product, reach that buyer's compliance process. If neither exists, get your documentation to trusted researchers, human-rights organisations, and journalists who can carry it outside. Do this through trusted allies, with attention to safety.

Fifth, protect your people above all. Favour quiet documentation and external channels over public confrontation. Keep your records secure and off-site. Do not take, or ask anyone to take, a risk out of proportion to what it can achieve. A living, united, documented community can keep fighting for years; an exposed one cannot.

That is the whole strategy in miniature: find the weak link, document the tenure and the process, reach outside, and keep people safe.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

This guide has been honest throughout that Myanmar's system is tilted against communities. This section addresses that tilt directly — what it does, how to read its severity, and how to act within it.

What This Tilt DOES (and DOESN'T DO)

What the tilt does: It removes the referees a community would normally rely on. Courts do not reliably enforce the rules against connected projects. Regulators have the power to act and often choose not to. Elected representatives cannot be leaned on as they can in a democracy. Open protest is dangerous. The default of the system is "yes" to the powerful proponent, and the ordinary domestic routes to "no" are largely closed.

What the tilt does not do: It does not make the truth untrue, and it does not reach outside the country's borders. A tilted domestic system cannot un-document a violation, cannot compel an international lender to ignore its own safeguards, cannot force a foreign buyer to accept legal and reputational risk, and cannot stop the world from learning what is happening. The tilt closes the domestic doors; it does not close the external ones. This is precisely why this guide points your strength toward documentation and external channels — they are the levers the tilt cannot disable.

Reading Your Tilt: Responsive, Mixed, Entrenched

Not every project sits under the same degree of tilt, and reading yours accurately sets your goal.

A **relatively responsive** situation is a private, mid-sized project dependent on outside finance or export markets, in an area where quiet documentation and external engagement are feasible. Here, stopping or substantially reshaping the project is genuinely possible, because the external levers have real force.

A **mixed** situation involves some connection to power but also real external exposure — a joint venture with both a connected partner and an international financier or buyer. Here, delay, mitigation, footprint reduction, and improved compensation are realistic, and outright stoppage is possible if the external pressure is strong enough.

An **entrenched** situation is a State or military-linked project serving a strategic or revenue purpose, with no international financing or export market to pressure, in a tightly controlled area. Here, outright stoppage is unlikely, and the honest goals are delay, documentation for the future and for accountability, protection of the most vital areas, and the best achievable compensation and relocation.

Diagnose your situation before you set your goal, because a goal that fits a responsive project will fail — and may endanger people — if the reality is entrenched, and a goal set only for an entrenched project surrenders leverage you actually had.

Documented Myanmar Dynamics

Several dynamics recur and should inform your reading. Resource wealth has long flowed to the State and connected networks rather than to the communities where extraction happens. The land laws — especially the VFV framework — operate as a legal mechanism of dispossession concentrated in ethnic areas. Environmental review has been weak and often pro forma even before the coup, and weaker since. Repression of dissent has intensified, narrowing the space for open opposition and raising its cost. And yet external attention has moved flagship projects, land-rights documentation has supported real claims, and communities that organised quietly and reached outside have delayed, reshaped, and occasionally stopped what threatened them. Both halves of that picture are true, and both should shape your expectations.

Assessment Framework — Determine Your Situation

To place your project, answer honestly: Who is behind it, and how exposed are they to outside money and markets? Is there an international lender or foreign buyer to pressure? Is the land taken from customary or ethnic users, giving you a strong tenure claim? How tightly is the area controlled, and how severe is the risk to people who object? The answers locate you on the responsive-mixed-entrenched spectrum and tell you whether to aim for stoppage, for reshaping and delay, or for documentation, protection, and better terms. Set your goal to fit the answer, not to fit your hopes.

Direct Action: Factual Information (Descriptive, Not Prescriptive)

Communities sometimes ask about direct, public action — demonstrations, blockades, occupations. This guide will be plain and factual: under present conditions in Myanmar, open public action against a project or the authorities carries severe personal risk, including arrest, imprisonment, violence, and worse, and it often does not reach the actors who can actually move the project. This is a description of reality, not a judgment of those who resist. This guide recommends that strength be channelled into quiet documentation and external leverage rather than public confrontation. Where people nonetheless consider public action, they should do so only with clear-eyed knowledge of the risk and no illusion that this guide can make such action safe.

Honest Assessment

The honest bottom line is this: the tilt is real and, at present, severe, and it makes outright victory against a connected project unlikely and open resistance dangerous. But the tilt does not close every door. It closes the domestic ones and leaves open the external ones — documentation, land-rights claims, lender and buyer complaints, international attention — and those are the doors through which real outcomes still come. A community that understands this, sets a fitting goal, documents carefully, reaches outside wisely, and protects its people can achieve delay, mitigation, protection, compensation, and sometimes more — while keeping its people alive and free. In present-day Myanmar, that is the difference this method is built to make.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Sometimes the obstacle is not merely a tilted system but active corruption and capture: officials personally benefiting from the project, connected interests overriding the rules, decisions bought. Recognising this changes your strategy, because a captured decision-maker cannot be persuaded on the merits — the merits are not what is deciding.

The signs of capture are recognisable. Rules are applied to the community's disadvantage and waived for the proponent. Documents that should be public are withheld. Consultations are staged. Officials who should be neutral advocate for the project. Objections vanish without response. Beneficial ownership is hidden behind layers. The same names recur across the deals. Where you see these patterns, you are not dealing with a system that will respond to a better argument; you are dealing with one whose outcome is already bought.

When a decision is captured, the response is to route around it. Do not spend your strength appealing to the captured body; it will not move. Instead, document the capture itself — the irregularities, the withheld documents, the conflicts of interest, the beneficial ownership — because that documentation is exactly what external forums act on. A lender's mechanism, a foreign buyer, an international investigator, and the wider public respond powerfully to evidence of corruption and hidden ownership, precisely because it demonstrates that the domestic process cannot be trusted. Capture that closes the domestic door often opens the external one wider, because it converts a mere land or environmental dispute into a documented account of wrongdoing that outside actors cannot ignore.

Handle this work with particular care for safety. Documenting corruption and powerful ownership touches the most dangerous interests, and it must be done quietly, with protection of identities, and with expert guidance. But done carefully, it turns the very fact of capture — which seems like the community's greatest obstacle — into the evidence that moves the actors the captors cannot control.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

Realistic 12-Month Campaign Timeline

A Myanmar campaign unfolds over months and often years, and its phases overlap. The following is a realistic shape for a first year, always subject to the overriding constraints of safety and the specific situation.

Months 1-2: Foundation and diagnosis. Answer the target-identification questions, above all who is behind the project and how it is funded and sold. Establish the security practices that will govern everything. Begin baseline and tenure documentation with a small trusted core. Set a goal that fits your situation on the responsive-mixed-entrenched spectrum.

Months 2-4: Documentation and quiet alignment. Build the three documentation layers — baseline, project and process, human and institutional impact. Align the affected households around a shared, accurate account and a clear goal. Make first careful contact with trusted civil-society, land-rights, and legal-aid allies.

Months 4-8: Coalition and external preparation. Widen the circle quietly to neighbouring communities and supporting networks. Identify and prepare the external lever that fits your project — the lender complaint, the buyer approach, or the international documentation route — with expert help. Use any procedural or land-rights filing to build the record and create delay.

Months 6-12: Escalation through external channels. File and pursue the external complaint. Feed it, and the journalists and bodies you have engaged, with fresh dated evidence. Maintain unity, security, and morale through the long phase. Be ready to act when a window opens — a financing decision, a buyer's review, a political shift.

Throughout, two things govern the pace: the strength of your evidence and the safety of your people. Never let the timeline push either.

Warning Signs — Act Early

Certain signs mean a window is closing and you must act. Survey teams, fencing, or clearing beginning. Land-classification or acquisition notices appearing. A compliance certificate about to issue. Financing about to close. Consultation announced with little notice. When you see these, move to secure your documentation and engage your external levers, because each marks the completion of a step that closes a window. Acting early — while a step is still incomplete — is far more effective than reacting after it is done.

Key Principles (What Separates Winning Campaigns from Losing Ones)

The campaigns that achieve something in Myanmar share a pattern. They diagnose their situation honestly and set a goal that fits it. They put their strength into documentation and external levers, not domestic confrontation. They protect their people relentlessly, favouring quiet, careful action over public risk. They build unity and keep it. They frame their cause around land, livelihood, environment, and law rather than politics or ethnicity. They enlist expert allies early. And they endure, keeping the record current and the pressure alive until a window opens. The campaigns that fail misjudge their leverage, rely on domestic courts and protests that cannot deliver here, fracture under pressure, expose their people, or give up before the external levers can work.

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Real Outcomes: What Winning Looks Like

Recalibrate what victory means, because in Myanmar it rarely looks like a clean, total stoppage announced in a courtroom. Winning looks like a project delayed long enough to lose its financing or be overtaken by events. It looks like a footprint shrunk, a sacred forest or a village spared, a river protected. It looks like an unlawful VFV classification reversed, or land returned. It looks like compensation and relocation transformed from a coerced pittance into something lawful and humane. It looks like a lender's mechanism opening an investigation, a foreign buyer walking away, an international record built that constrains the project or supports accountability later. And sometimes — as the country's most famous dam fight showed — it looks like even a flagship project suspended.

Decision Point: Continue, Modify, or Reassess

Periodically, step back and assess honestly. Is the situation responsive, mixed, or entrenched — and does your goal still fit it? Are the external levers you identified real and being pursued? Is the community united, the documentation current, the people safe? If the levers are working, continue. If the situation has changed — a new financier, a buyer's review, a political shift, or a hardening of control — modify your goal and tactics to fit. If the risk to people has risen beyond what any achievable outcome can justify, reassess, protect your people, preserve your documentation for a better moment, and live to fight another day. There is no shame in adjusting; there is harm in pressing a losing, dangerous course out of pride.

The Bottom Line

Myanmar is one of the hardest places in the world to stop a destructive project, and this guide has not pretended otherwise. The system is tilted, the courts unreliable, open resistance dangerous. But the tilt is not total. It closes the domestic doors and leaves the external ones open — the truth you document, the tenure rights you assert, the lenders and buyers you can reach, the world you can inform. A community that understands its situation, sets a goal that fits, documents with care, organises quietly, reaches outside wisely, and protects its people above all can achieve real and meaningful outcomes. That is the method this guide teaches, and in the hardest of circumstances it is the method most likely to save what matters most: the land, the livelihood, and the people who call it home.